

Last season, the team suffered a heartbreaking loss to Jaipur Pink Panthers in the summit clash. In its quest for a maiden PKL title, coach B.C. Ramesh and the management decided to take a few audacious calls during the auction ahead of the ongoing edition.

The team bid farewell to the seasoned Iranian duo of Fazel Atrachali and Mohammad Nabibakhsh and welcomed the young and versatile Mohammadreza Chiyaneh Shadloui. In their effort to place faith in the talent they have moulded, the captaincy reins were entrusted to Aslam Mustafa Inamdar, a young talent who has blossomed in the Paltan fold over three seasons.

As of February 12, the side has played 19 matches, won 14, drawn two and collected 81 points. It boasts an impressive score difference of 233. The second-best score difference is a faraway 88, belonging to the Panthers.

"Like every sport, kabaddi is also evolving. There's no set pattern; new ideas and approaches take it forward. I wanted a team of hungry youngsters with the right mindset," Ramesh tells *Sportstar*.

All-round modus operandi

The Puneri Paltan brand of kabaddi has always valued allrounders. This season, the side has managed to broaden the preference to the entire playing pool, with every player seamlessly transitioning between offence and defence. Led by the dynamic Inamdar, raiders like Mohit Goyat and Pankaj Mohite actively contribute to the team's defensive capabilities, often catching opponents off guard with their anticipation and cover skills.

The team's offensive strategy is well-distributed and multipronged. Players such as Aditya Shinde and Akash Shinde offer a good second wave to back the primary arsenal. Even a 'defender' like Chiyaneh consistently delivers crucial raids, keeping the opposition uncertain and their back line guessing.

Inamdar is the perfect prototype



for the franchise's preferred gameplan. The 23-year-old humbly attributes the team's success to their collective effort.

"We're playing like a team. We know we have to help each other in defence. Kabaddi is a team game where you have to hold the hands of your teammates," says Inamdar, who played a vital part in India's victorious Asian Kabbadi Championship and the Asian Games campaigns in 2023.

The results speak for themselves. Of the six teams that make the playoffs, Paltan has already qualified for the semifinals (top two teams automatically make the semis, while the other four battle it out in playoffs), with three games to spare.

Distributed defensive dominance

Versatility and high skills aside, what keeps the Paltan ticking is teamwork and a conscious effort to work on strengthening that element. This has led to the side's rise as the best defensive unit this season, with a success rate of 56.06 per cent and a total of 257 tackle points from 245 successful tackles, averaging 13.61 tackle points per match.

One of the key players in the team's defence is vice-captain and left-corner Chiyaneh. He is currently leading the individual defensive matrix with 72 tackle points along with 25 raid points. Inamdar's relief

On the prowl: Puneri Paltan's defensive unit in action against U Mumba in the ongoing season of PKL. PKL

to have the towering Iranian in his quarter is understandable.

"He is a brilliant all-rounder, one of the best defenders in the league, and a fierce competitor. He's always hungry on the mat, and I'm constantly learning from him. I'm very happy that he's my teammate and not an opponent," he says.

A new wave

Ramesh's preference for experimentation can be risky, but the team has welcomed the strategy with open arms by a young fearless bunch of talented players.

He says, "With dedication to skill development and innovative fitness regimens, young athletes are pushing the boundaries of the sport. Scouts seek multi-dimensional talent, valuing adaptability over one-dimensional expertise."

Puneri Paltan's journey is far from over. Its dominant showing this season makes it a favourite to make the final and potentially even lift the title for the first time.

With a fearless coach who is happy to innovate and a bunch of players who have bought into that brand of operation, the trophy is Puneri Paltan's to lose.